

declaring that the rights of traitorous former masters outweighed those who had “made these lands what they are.” They urged plaintively, “We wish to have a home if it be but a few acres. Without some provision ... our situation is dangerous.”

Sharecropping

Former slaves saw freedom in the same terms as Lincoln had done —“the God-given right to enjoy the fruits of their own labor”—yet they achieved minimal economic gains in the years after the war. The failure to obtain land or compensation left people few options. Without savings or influence, they were at the mercy of white landowners and politicians. A labor system known as “sharecropping” spread throughout the South, offering the illusion of upward mobility. This system bound tenant farmers to the land through an annual contract under which the tenant’s crop was “shared,” typically fifty-fifty, with the landowner. Several factors worked against the success of the system, including low crop prices, accumulated debts on the part of the sharecroppers to local merchants, and periods of crop failure. After harvest, many sharecroppers found themselves mired deep in debt. While a minority of them began to rise in life, many remained trapped in a poverty that affected them and the region for decades.